



AP English Language and Composition Review Guide

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Range: The Things They Carried by Tim O'Brien + Lit Devices

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I. Theme Chart

Theme	Examples	Purpose
Verisimilitude and Metafiction + Storytelling: Fact or Fiction	Shifting narration styles in "How to Tell a True War Story." → Illustrates the instability of truth in storytelling and the need to question how war is remembered. O'Brien admitting he made up much of the story in "Good Form." → Shows that emotional resonance can matter more than factual accuracy in conveying the trauma of war. Repeated contradictions of details (e.g., how Curt Lemon died). → Highlights how memory is fragmented and unreliable under emotional stress (key element of war story) O'Brien's layering of stories within stories, such as Linda's death mirroring other losses. → Underscores how storytelling becomes a coping mechanism, merging fact with feeling. One should only believe 60-70% of Rat Kiley's stories – exaggeration revealing emotional truths Vignette in "Speaking of Courage" and "Notes" showing multiple story angles Use of storytelling to revive Linda. → how stories can keep the dead alive. Framing the war through emotional, not literal, facts → allows the audience to understand the real implications of war + more than just the death count and major events. Reflects the human side of things	War resists simple truths. By mixing truth and fiction, O'Brien reveals that the emotional core of a story can convey more reality than factual accuracy ever could. It emphasizes the disorienting nature of trauma and the way memory reshapes experience to protect or explain the self. Stories are not just used to suggest and reflect a moral. Stories can keep the dead alive by giving them a new life and identity.
War and Love	Lt. Cross's obsession with Martha interfering with leadership. → Reveals how emotional ties can conflict with responsibility and survival. Cross burning Martha's letters and photos to commit to responsibility = conformity to wartime duty O'Brien remembering Linda as his first love to cope with death Henry Dobbins wearing his girlfriend's stockings around his neck. Love (or the idea of it) becomes protective,	O'Brien uses love to expose emotional vulnerability, not as romance, but as something almost sacred and irrational in the face of death. It becomes a tether to the world outside war.

	providing emotional security and superstition amidst chaos; a form of escapism/anchor to world back home	A war story can also be a love story. They are not black and white.
The Individual and the Collective	Personal items symbolizing each soldier's individuality	The tension between self and group speaks to how war is dehumanizing despite the efforts against it. O'Brien and Cross resists this by emphasizing that each soldier carries unique memories, traumas, and identities despite uniform appearances.
	Bowker unable to express his trauma to anyone post-war. Individual trauma and different experiences causing one to become isolated and invisible.	
	The idea that men from different walks of life converge to serve in the same platoon.	
Social Obligation	O'Brien deciding on the Rainy River to go to war just to avoid embarrassment (societal pressure overriding moral objection)	O'Brien suggests that the war wasn't driven by ideology as much as by shame, pressure, and conformity—forces stronger than reason. This is reflected through the war medals that Bowker is expected to get, and that he finds pointless. War is oftentimes meaningless.
	The crude names ("Turncoat", etc.) that O'Brien imagines people calling him because he wants to escape the drafting.	
	Bowker feeling like a failure for not winning medals → Public validation becomes a false measure of self-worth.	
	Pressure to avenge deaths, even when unjustified (crosses with moral ambiguity)	
Mortality and Death	Ted Lavender's sudden, meaningless death (lack of agency in the face of death, death becomes commonplace, with people waiting for their day to come)	Death in war is sudden, arbitrary, and humiliating. It does not matter who you are, whether you are a scholar or a criminal. Everyone is the same when faced with mortality, and who dies and who lives is completely based on randomness.
	Kiowa's death in the shitfield → the grotesque and inescapable presence of mortality.	
	Repeated storytelling about the Vietnamese soldier O'Brien killed.	
	Linda – connects a wider audience, makes the book more relatable by meshing wartime death with the universal experience of loss of loved ones	
Morality	O'Brien wanting to hurt Jorgenson out of revenge. → Reveals how war distorts ethical boundaries.	Characters make questionable decisions, not out of malice, but

+ Moral Ambiguity of the War	Kiley shooting a water buffalo to express pain, no one stopping him	survival, habit, or emotional chaos. O'Brien illustrates how traditional concepts of right and wrong dissolve in Vietnam's landscape.
	Unclear blame for Kiowa's death in the field. → no single person can be held accountable in chaos.	
	O'Brien's revenge prank on Jorgenson. (ethical erosion)	
Fear of Shame + Masculinity + Integrity	Mary Anne's transformation challenging male exclusivity in war. → Subverts traditional gender roles and exposes insecurity.	Masculinity in the novel is tied closely to fear—especially fear of appearing weak. The men carry not only weapons but the immense burden of reputation. Their integrity often hinges on conforming to a masculine ideal, even when it contradicts their inner truths. O'Brien critiques how shame—not patriotism—is what sends men to war and keeps them there. The soldiers are often tested with integrity, or saying and doing things that are correct but not popular. Most of the times, however, soldiers choose the popular side.
	Lemon fainting at the dentist = shame and embarrassment (succumbing to fear) getting a perfectly healthy tooth pulled = bravery and a re-intact reputation	
The Allure of War	Mary Anne's transformation into a jungle warrior. → war seduces and changes people irreversibly	War draws people to its adrenaline, clarity, and mythic energy. Mary Anne's transformation and recurring returns to violent memory suggest that war awakens a primal, completely engulfed by Vietnam and consuming fascination.
	O'Brien enjoying moments of revenge and thrill.	
	Fascination with weapons and gear. (Appeal of control and power amidst chaos)	
The Physical and Emotional Burdens of War +	The literal inventory in "The Things They Carried." + the invisible weight of fear, guilt, and memory.	The soldiers carry physical loads—guns, supplies, tokens—but their heaviest burdens are emotional: guilt, fear, loss, and longing. O'Brien
	Cross's emotional weight over Lavender's death.	

The Effect of Violence on Humans	Bowker's guilt about Kiowa.	shows that the weight of memory outlasts the war itself.
	O'Brien's psychological weight from killing – obsessing and rethinking details	
	Kiley's mental breakdown after Curt Lemon's death.	

II. Commonly-confused Lit Terms

- **Synecdoche** – When a part represents the whole (“wheels” for “car”)
- **Metonymy** – When something is referred to by something closely associated with it (“the crown” for “royalty”).
- **Anthropomorphism** – Giving human traits to animals or objects literally, often used in fables (e.g. talking animals in *Maus*); different from personification in that it focuses on animals, making animals figurative humans.
- **Personification** – Giving human qualities or feelings to non-human things (“the sun smiled”); more metaphorical.
- **Irony** (Types) – discrepancy between appearance and reality. Verbal irony=not meaning what is said; situational irony=a surprising ending; dramatic irony=the readers know more than the characters
- **Paradox** – A statement that seems contradictory but reveals a truth (“the more you know, the more you don't know”); often mistaken for oxymoron.
- **Oxymoron** – Two contradictory terms (“jumbo shrimp”)
- **Mood**-the atmosphere that the author constructs through diction and details; different from atmosphere in that mood is what the readers perceive and atmosphere is what the author establishes

III. Less-frequently-understood-but-still-important Lit Terms

- **Antimetabole** – Repetition of words in reverse grammatical order (“Eat to live, not live to eat”).
- **Anastrophe** – Synonym for inversion; inverted word order for emphasis or rhythm (“Powerful you have become”); sounds like Yoda-speak.

- **Epistrophe** – Repetition at the end of phrases or clauses (“...by the people, for the people”); opposite of anaphora.
- **Epanalepsis** – Same word at beginning and end of a sentence (“Nothing is worse than doing nothing”).
- **Asyndeton** – A list without conjunctions (“I came, I saw, I conquered”); often confused with polysyndeton.
- **Polysyndeton** – A list with many conjunctions (“He ran and jumped and shouted and danced...”).
- **Apposition** – A noun phrase that explains, modifies, or qualifies another noun (“Ms. Sedlock, our teacher,...”); a grammar term that pops up in literature analysis.
- **Apostrophe** – Direct address to an absent, imaginary, or dead person/thing (“O Romeo...”)

IV. ChatGPT Tips for Literary Analysis

Prompt: “give me some tips for lit analysis. im good at writing, i want to be excellent 😊”

1. Turn Your Analysis into Argument

Insightful analysis is not just close reading—it’s a form of argument.

Instead of simply observing literary devices, *frame your analysis as a claim about human behavior, ideology, or emotional truth.*

- ❌ *O’Brien uses metafiction to show how storytelling helps him process trauma.*
- ✅ *O’Brien’s metafictional layers suggest that the line between fiction and truth dissolves under trauma—not because memory fails, but because reality itself becomes unlivable.*

→ **The difference: one identifies a device; the other takes a stand.**

2. Layer Interpretations, Not Just Evidence

Go beyond “what this means” to “what this *also* could mean.”

Look for **interpretive friction**—places where one image or moment can mean multiple things at once. *Tension is where the complexity lives.*

Example:

Mary Anne's transformation into a feral killer isn't just a loss of innocence. It's a metaphor for war's erotic pull, the colonial fantasy of Vietnam, and the collapse of Western femininity under foreign pressure.

→ Ask: What's beneath the obvious? What's in conflict here?

3. Collapse the Distance Between Form and Meaning

Don't treat literary devices as separate from content. Instead, **make your analysis show that the form is the content.**

-  *The repetition emphasizes the speaker's trauma.*
-  *The obsessive repetition enacts trauma—forcing the reader into the same loop of memory the speaker cannot escape.*

This is more than pointing out literary techniques. This is showing that **how something is written is what it means.**

4. Make the Text Uncomfortable

Excellent analysis is unafraid to:

- Question a narrator's reliability
- Challenge what the author might be avoiding
- Point out contradictions in theme or tone

O'Brien presents storytelling as healing, but his recursive grief over Kiowa and the Vietnamese soldier suggests that no story can truly absolve him—only numb him.

This shows that you're not just following the text, but *wrestling* with it.

5. Elevate with Thematic Synthesis

The highest-level writing doesn't just explain *parts of a text*—it **braids themes together into new insight.**

For example, take two themes like "masculinity" and "memory" from *The Things They Carried*:

The men's silence around fear—framed as masculinity—is not just repression; it's a collective reshaping of memory itself. Their manhood depends on editing the past. In

O'Brien's world, masculinity is not about truth, but about the stories men allow each other to believe.

→ **This is synthesis**—not just linking themes, but fusing them into a deeper argument about identity, narrative, and social structure.

(this section was generated by an AI chatbot)

Good Luck Everyone! 😊